Orig to War Dept Sep 19

Mr Adee

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No.305

EMBASSY OF THE UNITED STATES.

St.Petersburg, September 1,1900.

2D ASSISTANT SECRETARY
Ack & file.
SEP 19 1900

Mr.Peirce

To the Honorable Alvey A.Adee,

Acting Secretary of State

Subject:- Acknowledges the receipt of the Department's telegram of August 29th,and confirms his cipher telegrem of August 31st,1900. Both relating to the situation in China.

No.303. EMBASSY OF THE UNITED STATES.

St.Petersburg, September 1,1900.

To the Honorable

Alvey A.Adee,

Acting Secretary of State

Washington/D.C.

Sir:-

I have the honor to acknowledge the receipt of your telegram dated August 29,1900, a copy of which, together with my reply thereto I append upon the overleaf.

Immediately upon receipt of your telegram I addressed a note to Count Lamsdorff asking for a special interview which he accorded me yesterday at half past eleven o'clock.

I read to him carefully the text of your telegram leaving a copy with him as a memorandum. The count listened with very great interest and when I had finished he expressed satisfaction that the Government of the United States will consent to withdraw from Peking but regret that apparently the Russian Charge d'Affaires had not made the purposes and views of the Russian Government clearly understood by you. He asked me therefore to telegraph you the substance of his remarks which I believe I have faithfully done, so far as the reasonable limits of telegraphic communication permit.

I will however repeat his remarks in extenso.

In your telegram you quoted the Russian Charge d'Affaires as having said "Russia has directed the Russian Minister to retire with his official porsonnel from China and that the Russian troops will likewise be withdrawn". Count Lamsdorff was especially desirous that this impression be corrected. He said that there is no intention of withdrawing either the Russian Minister or the Russian troops from China, but that they are about to retire from

Peking and remain at Tientsin awaiting developments.

In explaining to me the motives which actuate the Russian Government in arriving at this decision, which he is anxious that you should fully understand, he said: repeating much of what I communicated in my despatch No.298 of August 28th: That Russia, in common with the other Powers, had made certain declarations regarding the Chinese troubles to which the Russian Government feels strictly bound to adhere.

These are that war in China is not existant, and that the object of the military relief expedition to Peking and its entry into the city was to rescue the Legations and those under their protection, and that one of the purposes of the presence of Russian forces in China is to aid the Chinese Government to restore order.

That, the declared object of the relief expedition being accomplished, it is the strict duty of Russia to withdraw her forces from Peking, since their remaining there would be of the nature of a military occupation of the Capital of the country, constituting an act of war, and that, far from aiding the Chinese Government to restore order, such an act would paralyze the functions of the Government, at least temporarily, and diminish its power in the restoration of order by discrediting it with the Chinese people.

He therefore deems that good faith and the dignity of Russia requires the withdrawal of the Russian forces from Peking.

In addition to these arguments he considers that as a matter of policy, in the interest of a speedy return to peaceful conditions in China, and the negotiation of terms satisfactory to the Powers, he believes that the withdrawal of all the forces from Peking to Tientsin would be advan-

tageous.

The whereabouts of the Chinese Government is at present unknown but he believes that it exists as a potentially de facto Government and that, if it is prevented by foreign occupation of its capital from return there, it will establish a new seat of Government in some inaccessible place in the interior, where it will be extremely difficult to deal with it. On the other hand, that if Peking is evacuated by the forces of the Powers, that Government will return and reestablish itself there, where it is practically within reach of negotiations from Tientsin.

He considers also that terms negotiated from Tientsin would have more valid force than would terms wrested from China under the compulsion of the presence of armed forces within the Capital.

Moreover he regards the occupation of Peking as fraught with grave responsibilities in the preservation of order and the protection of life and property, which he regards it as unnecessary and superfluous to incur.

He stated that it is the purpose of the Russian Government to retain its Minister and forces at Tientsin, the former to negotiate with the Plenipotentiary of the Chinese Government whenever the time for such negotiations shall arrive, and, in the event of the refusal of the Chinese Government to accede to the just demands of the Powers, it would be the policy of Russia to present an ultimatum to China and, if necessary, to enforce it by a declaration of war. He believes however that the Chinese Government will quickly put itself in negotiation with the Powers upon the evacuation of Peking and will promptly accede to all reasonable demands.

He reiterated the earnest desire of Russia to act concurrently and in unison with the other Powers regarding

Copy of telegram received.

WASHINGTON, August 29,1900.

PEIRCE - CHARGÉ,

ST.PETERSBURG.

August 29,1900. The Russian Chargé d'Affaires yesterday afternoon, made to me an oral statement respecting Russia's purposes in China to the following effect: that, as already repeatedly declared, Russia has no designs of territorial acquisition in China; that, equally with other Powers now operating there, Russia has sought safety of the Legations at Peking and to help the Chinese Government to repress the troubles; that incidentally to necessary defensive measures on Russian border, Russia has occupied New Hang for military purposes and as soon as order is reestablished will retire troops therefrom, if action of other Powers he no obstacle thereto; that the purpose for which the various Governments have cooperated for relief of Legations in Peking has been acccmplished; that, taking the position that as the Chinese Government has left Peking there is no need for her representative to remain, Russia as directed the Russian Minister to retire with his official personnel from China; that the Russian troops will likewise be withdrawn; and that, when the Government of China shall regain the reins of Government and afford an authority with which the other Powers can deal, and will express the desire to enter in negotiations, the Russian Government will also name its representative, holding these views and purposes. Russia expresses the hope that the United States will share the same purpose.

To this declaration our reply has been made by the following memorandum:

"The Government of the United States receives with

much satisfaction the reiterated statement that Russia has no designs of territorial acquisition in China, and that, equally with the other powers now operating in China, Russia has sought the safety of her Legation in Peking and to help the Chinese Government to repress the existing troubles. The same purposes have moved, and will continue to control the Government of the United States, and the frank declaration of Russia in this regard are in accord with those made to the United States by the other Powers. All the Powers therefore having disclaimed any purpose to acquire any part of China, and now that adherence thereto has been renewed since relief has reached Peking, it ought not to be difficult, by concurrent action through negotiations, to reach an amicable settlement with China by which the treaty rights of all the Powers will be secured for the future, the open door assured, the interests and property of foreign citizens conserved and full reperation made for wrongs and injuries suffered by them. So far as we are advised the greater part of China is at peace and earnestly desires to protect the life and property of all foreigners and, in several of the provinces, active and successful efforts to suppress the boxers have been taken by the Viceroys to whom we have extended encouragement through our Consuls and naval officers. This present good relation should be promoted for the peace of China. While we agree that the immediate object for which the military forces of the Powers have been cooperating, viz: the relief of the Ministers at Peking has been accomplished, there still remain the other purposes which all the Powers have in common, which are referred to in the communication of the Russian Charge d' Affaires, and which were specially enumerated in our note to the Powers of July third. These are to afford all possible protection, everywhere in China, to foreign life and

property, to guard and protect all legitimate foreign interests, to aid in preventing the spread of the disorders, and to seek a solution which may bring about permanent safety and peace to China, preserve Chinese territorial and administrative entity, protect all rights guaranteed by treaty and international law to friendly Powers, and safeguard for the World the principle of equal and impartial trade with all parts of the Chinese Empire".

"In our opinion these purposes could best be attained by the joint occupation of Peking under definite understanding between the Powers until the Chinese Government shall have been re-established and shall be in a position to enter into new treaties with adequate provisions for reparation and guaranties of future protection. With the establishment and rerognition of such authority the United States would wish to withdraw its military forces from Peking and remit to the processes of peaceful negotiations our just demands. We consider however that a continued occupation of Peking would be ineffective to produce the desired results unless all the Powers unite therein with entire harmony of purpose. Any Power which determines to withdraw its troops from Peking will necessarily proceed thereafter to protect its interests in China by its own method and we think that this would make a general withdrawal expedient".

"As to the time and manner of withdrawal we think that in view of the imperfect knowledge of the military situation, resulting from the interruption of telegraphic communication, the several military Commanders at Peking should be instructed to confer and agree together upon the withdrawal as a concerted movement, as they agreed upon the advance."

"The results of these considerations is that, unless

there is such a general expression by the Powers in favor of continued occupation as to modify the views expressed by the Government of Russia and lead to a general agreement for continued occupetion,we shall give instructions to the Commander of the American forces in China to withdraw our troops from Peking after due conference with the other Commanders as to the time and manner of withdrawal..

"The Government of the United States is much gratified by the assurance given by Russia that the occupation of New Chang is for military purposes incidental to the military steps for the security of the Russian border provinces, menaced by the Chinese, and that, as soon as order shall be reestablished, Russia will retire her troops from these places if the action of the other Powers be not an obstacle thereto. No obstacle in this regard can arise through any action of the United States whose policy is fixed and has been repeatedly proclaimed. Signed- dated August twenty-ninth".

You will communicate the foregoing to the Minister for Foreign Affairs and invite early consideration and response.

ADEE, Acting.

Translation of cipher telegram sent.

St.Petersburg, August 31,1900.

SECSTATE - WASHINGTON.

I had an interview with Count Lamsdorff this morning and communicated the text your telegram of the twenty-ninth received last night. At his request I communicate by telegraph the following: The Government of Russia is gratified to be informed that the Government of the United States will consent to withdraw troops from Peking; but Count Lamsdorff regrets that the Russian Charge d'Affaires has not clearly defined the views and purposes of Russia. The Government of Russia has no intention to withdraw Russian Minister or Russian forces from China but from Peking. They are about to retire and remain at Tientsin and await further developments, their motives for this action are that Russia in common with other Powers has declared that war not existing, that the entry into Peking was for the purpose of rescuing Legations and that one of the reasons for the presence of Russian forces in China is to aid the Government of China to restore order . In view of these declarations Russia considers that to remain in Peking after the declured purpose of the relief is accomplished would not be in accordance with the assurances to which it is pledged and far from aiding the Government of China to restore order it would tend to discredit the Government of China with the Chinese people and temporarily, at least, paralyze its functions it would he of necessity a military occupation, itself a belligerent act and it would involve grave responsibilities and difficulties in maintaining order. Furthermore it is believed that it would greatly increase the difficulties in negotiating with the Chinese Government which if the Capital is occupied will find a

new and inaccessible seat further in the interior. On the other hand Russia believes that if the forces and Ministers retire to Tientsin the Government of China will reestablish itself in Peking and that then it will be much more practicable to negotiate and thut the terms thus agreed to would bave greater validity than if wrested compulsorily from them in the course of the negotiations if the Government of China refuses to accede to the just demands of the Powers it would be the policy of Russia to present an ultimatum to be enforced if necessary by a declaration of war. But it is believed that peace will foliow quickly witndrawal fron Peking. The above is submitted to you for consideration at the request of Count Lumsdorff.

PEIRCE.